

Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness — Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · YouTube Talks · 21:29

There's a lovely German word for when you try to make it something better only to make it worse. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, although I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sambhasambuddhassa.

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Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-awakened one.

I just want to mention, some of you might not know, the online meditation hall, which is on the Zoom. And the times are 6 a.m., nice and early, fresh, 9 a.m., 11 a.m., so that's 6, 9, 11 in the morning, and 2 p.m., 4 p.m., and 6 p.m. in the afternoon. And in the morning at 6 a.m., Noreen is normally here, and I'm hoping to be here at 2 p.m. Noreen will also be here. If you want to get on the Zoom to stop Zoom bombing and all that, you have to get in touch with Mark. There he is, there's Mark. Hi Mark, I'm just wondering if you'd like to put your email up so that people can contact you if they want to be on the online meditation hall.

So that's an online meditation or you can join. You can go on anytime actually, but those are the times set where you might meet people there—6, 9, 11 in the morning and 2, 4, 6 in the afternoon. Mark's put it up there. That's Mark Arthur. So if you want to take that email, he'll let you in. He's the gatekeeper. We don't pay him anything.

So now just to carry on with the foundations of mindfulness, as Bhikkhu Bodhi calls it, discourse number 10. It's the jewel of the collection, remember. And we finished the body part. So that contained the breathing, of course, the whole instructions on breath meditation, the four postures—standing, walking, sitting and lying down—full awareness, continual awareness during the day, the foulness of the body, which remember is really to do with becoming disenchanted with the body, disinterested with it. And of course, the good old charnel grounds. Oh, elements, the elements, the four basic elements that point to where our physicality and mentality meet at the sense door. That's the retina, the eardrum and so forth. And the nine charnel grounds, yes, the nine bodies that are slowly corrupting into pure dust, to dust thou shalt return.

So the next one is feeling. Now, I've actually done quite a bit on that already on talk number 28, if you want to look it up. But we'll read it through and it's pretty straightforward.

And how does one abide contemplating feelings as feelings? Now, remember, he's translating it as feelings. But to me, the grammar is to feel feelings in feelings. In a sense, they both mean the same thing—feeling as feeling, feelings in feelings. But the idea of being right in there, like in a room, in the bath, like you're sunk in. So whatever feeling that is, the idea is to get into it and really feel it. Open up to it completely, absorb into it, you might say.

Here, when feeling a pleasant feeling, the meditator understands, "I feel a pleasant feeling." Now remember, you're not supposed to be saying to yourself, "I am feeling a pleasant feeling." It's just a recognition that you're feeling a pleasant feeling. It's a consciousness. You're aware of it. And when feeling a painful feeling, he understands, "I feel a painful feeling." When feeling a neither painful nor pleasant feeling, he understands, "I feel a neither painful nor pleasant feeling."

So there's the neutral bit. Actually, if you look close enough, feelings will always shade ever so slightly towards pleasant, ever so slightly towards unpleasant, and that's the dual world that we live in. I mean that's apparent to us, I think even in the womb, that there are pleasant feelings and unpleasant feelings. And this whole area that we would call neutral. And of course, it's upon neutral feelings that we can establish that calmness, that peace. That's why the breath, walking meditation—so they do have their purpose in our practice.

And then he knows when there's a worldly feeling—a worldly pleasant feeling and a worldly unpleasant feeling, and a neither pleasant nor unpleasant worldly feeling. And he knows when an unworldly feeling is there. So worldly and unworldly. So we did this, of course, way back there.

So worldly feelings are just to do with being in the world. The sensual world is to do with the work we're doing, whatever we're experiencing, eating, etc. The unworldly feelings are all to do with the spiritual side. So it's to do with renunciation, letting go of things with compassion, love, worldly feelings that come through our practice, peacefulness, the factors of enlightenment, equanimity and things like that. So anything to do with the spiritual life is unworldly. That's the word for it. Anything to do with the world is worldly. That doesn't necessarily mean it's unwholesome. If you're doing worldly, like the work you're doing, for instance, will have a worldly purpose. You've got to earn money and so forth. But it doesn't make it unwholesome. But that doesn't lead to liberation. What leads to liberation are the investigation of these three characteristics—remember how we cause suffering, the process of wrong desire, impermanence and not self.

And there's the usual refrain—he abides contemplating feelings as feelings internally, but he also notices such feelings in other people. You can tell it on their face and so forth. And if you're sensitive enough, sometimes you can actually feel how they feel. If they're joyous, you can feel the joy being mirrored on the surface of your own heart, equally so anger and all that. And he abides feeling feelings both internally and externally. He also abides contemplating feelings in their arising factors and abides contemplating feelings in their vanishing factors, and abides contemplating feelings in both their arising and falling. So

that's basically being aware that everything is always in process, always consistently changing. That's the one thing that never changes.

Or else mindfulness that "there is feeling" is simply established in him to the extent necessary for bare knowledge and mindfulness. And he abides independent. So this last phrase is really the position of *vipassanā*, where finally you're just resting on the object, observing it very carefully. And there is this background view of it, which is looking at it from the point of view of any reaction that we have to it—it's impermanence and not self. It's just a way of looking.

And just enough. He says just enough knowledge. Actually, the word is just enough intuitive awareness, actually. Just bare knowledge and mindfulness, bare knowledge and mindfulness. So it's just that ability to observe with that open curiosity, with the intelligence awakened—that intuitive intelligence awake. And that's just part of that whole of awareness. Remember, there's the active and the passive. So the passive is when we're receiving stuff and the active is when we actually grasp what's happening. First you look and then you see. And he abides independent, not clinging to anything in the world. So let go of the world as such. So that's the whole section on feeling.

Now, it is an important section because if you ask yourself—if you look into your body, especially feelings that are caused by the mind. So there are two—this doesn't actually say that, but there are two different types of feelings. Remember, feelings coming from the body—pain, discomfort, sense of pleasure, itching, all those sorts of things. And pleasure and pleasant feelings coming from the heart, from mental states.

And when you say you're happy, just ask yourself, what do you mean by that? Do you mean you have happy thoughts? Or is it a sensation? Or is it more a feeling of being a happy feeling in us? Do we rate our happiness by how we feel rather than what we're thinking, or actually or the physical state? If I put something in my mouth which is sweet, do I say that this is happiness? No, that's just sweetness. But if the sweetness makes me happy and I say, "Oh, I'm happy. I'm happy because of the sweetness." And we often judge our lives according to whether we're happy or not. So if I'm not being happy, I find that I'm wasting my life or I'm finding that my life isn't worth living anymore.

See, so it's important to find that distance from feeling and not to be governed by them, not to personalise them. There it is. There is now a happy feeling. There is now a sad feeling. Now get on with what you have to do. As soon as you identify with it, you say, "I am happy, I am depressed," etc. And in a sense, you've locked yourself in. It's like an imprisonment. So that's the section on feeling.

The next section is also pretty straightforward, the section on mind or mental states. So these include both your thinking, your imagining, etc., and just general mental states as such of which feeling is part of it, of which the body, of course, comes in somewhere.

So how does one abide contemplating the mind as the mind? He understands a mind affected by lust. He's got lust here, but that's pretty heavy lust and it tends to be around erotic desires, but it could be any sort of

desire—the mind affected by wrong desire. He understands the mind affected by wrong desire as a mind affected by wrong desire and the mind unaffected by wrong desire as a mind unaffected by wrong desire.

It's also recognising actually when there's no desire in us and how does that feel? How does that feel when there's no desire? So it's not only the negative bit or that, you know, I'm overcome by this desire and whatnot, but how does it feel when it finishes? When it ends? And the same with hatred—a mind affected by hatred, a mind unaffected by aversion or hatred. So again, if we are in an adverse state, when it comes to an end and the aversion passes and the mind is just empty of those sorts of feelings, how does that feel?

So when we begin to experience the heart-mind—I should say heart really—the heart-mind as a pleasant place to be, when we begin to experience directly a heart-mind which is not caught up in wrong desires or some form of aversion or whatever, then of course we tend to go there. We tend to go there. So remember that we're always caught up with being excited, always trying to exercise a certain emotional mental state. What's it like when there isn't any there? When it's just a sense of peacefulness, calmness? And delusion as well, so that's the mind which is perhaps in a sense of doubt, confused.

The next one is a contracted mind. So this is much the same—it's contracted by wrong desires, aversions, things like that, sloth and torpor, wrong sort of tiredness, dullness in the head, lethargy in the body. That's caused by acts of laziness. So that is a contracted mind, whereas a distracted mind is one that is governed by restlessness. Mind going all over the place. Obsessive thinking, that sort of thing. So it's a case of just knowing what the mind is actually doing, what the heart-mind is actually doing.

He understands an exalted mind and an unexalted mind. So that's to do with the *jhānas*, really, these absorption states. So mostly we're not in an absorption state. He understands a surpassed mind as a surpassed mind and an unsurpassed mind. So this is, again, just in these absorption states—exalted, unsurpassed. These are all very high, very refined states of mind. And the unexalted ones and the surpassed ones are really to do with just the worldly states of mind.

And then there's the concentrated mind, of course, and the unconcentrated mind. So you can see they all shade into each other. It's just slightly different ways of looking at it. And then finally, the liberated mind and the unliberated. That's not to do with final liberation. That's just to do with the fact that when we're in an insightful mode, then the heart-mind is liberated. And when we're in a *jhāna*, in more of an absorbed, concentrated state, then the mind is liberated from hindrances.

And he abides contemplating the mind as mind internally and externally. So you can see these moods and emotions, mental states in other people, can't you? Even in their body language. And he abides contemplating the mind again with the arising factors and the vanishing factors. So it's again always this impermanence, always this impermanence. And then finally, just this—this is the mental state—and he abides independent, not clinging to anything in the world. So that covers the next two sections of feeling and the mind itself. And the next one is the mind objects. And we'll tackle that tomorrow because that's a whole new section.

Really, it's just ways of looking at what we're experiencing. And remember that when we open up to something, say an emotional state, say we're full of joy, there's always that tendency to want to try and develop it. So we're always looking at that reaction. See, we're not getting caught up either in the joy or the reaction to it. And we're just watching that process. That's all, just watching the process and watching that desire to indulge just begin to fade away. Then we come back to the joy and there's that mental joy, that mental state.

And then you can go into it to find out, well, what's it made of at that basic level? And how is it affecting the body? How does the body feel when we're in a state of joy? Then you can move from those two different levels of perception. The perception of those four elements—some form of lightness, of warmth, etc. And then when you come to the next level of perception, you find this warm joy, and you recognise it as joy. So there are different ways that you can play around within yourself, just slowly deconstructing things. And this takes away that sense of solidity.

And in so doing, unwittingly, of course, we are establishing this position of the observer and it's there that we want to stay as best we can. That's in the meditation. Of course, as you begin to absorb, as you begin to become very concentrated in what you're seeing, then remember that that reflexive moment of the awareness being aware of itself as the observer, as the feeler, can disappear and with it time. And when you come out of that you can always say to yourself, oh well that was a moment of pure *vipassanā*, you might say. That doesn't make the other type of *vipassanā* with the observer impure—not at all. Insights are just insights. They come at any time.

So just work with what you have that comes up and you just see it as something to investigate, constantly awakening that sense of curiosity.

So I think we've done for this evening. And if you want to, there are those times—remember I'll just remind you again just in case. So this is the Zoom at 6 a.m.—yes, wonderful time—and they also start, there's a chanting starts at 10 to 7 and finishes 10 past thereabouts. Then there's a 9 a.m., 11 a.m., so it's 6, 9, 11, and then in the afternoon 2, 4 and 6. And of course when you join you stay as long as you want. If it's 10 minutes, it's 10 minutes. If it's an hour, it's an hour.

So hopefully you'll take advantage of this if you're still in firm lockdown, if it's just you in a room or in a house. So you might want to take advantage of that. Very good. I can only hope my words have been some assistance. May you by your fierce determination be liberated sooner rather than later. So we can begin our practice.

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